

Saudi Arabia & Yemen conflict update

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Conference Call Note

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Saudi Arabia & Yemen conflict update

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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The Saudi-backed campaign in Yemen is underperforming relative to official claims because the Houthis retain control of Bab el-Mandeb, have made gains in Taiz, and will continue attacking Saudi infrastructure regardless of battlefield developments.

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Saudi Arabia faces a three-front threat from Houthis to the south, Iraqi militias to the north, and Iran to the east, which one speaker characterized as an existential risk to the kingdom.

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Normalization between Saudi Arabia and Israel is not dead but remains contingent on Israeli concessions to the Palestinians, and Riyadh may seek to join the Abraham Accords before President Donald Trump leaves office if Israeli elections produce a more amenable government.

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Speaker:

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Bernard Haykel, Professor and Director, Institute for Trans-Regional Studies of the Contemporary Middle East, North Africa and Central Asia, Princeton University; author of a forthcoming book on Mohammed bin Salman (MBS)

Moderator:

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Firas Maksad, Managing Director, Middle East and North Africa, Eurasia Group

The Ground War: Underperforming Headlines

The Saudi-backed offensive in Yemen is not going as well as official statements suggest. Houthis retain control of Bab el-Mandeb and the strategic coastal areas they seized and have scored significant gains in Taiz. Government forces' claims of major coastal victories are not accurate.

The Saudi strategy is sequential: stabilize the coast and Taiz, then move to Hudaydah, then Ma'rib and Sana'a. But that progression depends on anti-Houthi forces—currently divided between Saudi-backed northern factions and UAE-aligned southern ones—fighting cohesively. That has not materialized. Saudi air cover has not been sufficient to reverse Houthi advances, and a video of government forces running over Houthi combatants has reinforced Houthi resolve to resist.

The Houthis can disrupt Red Sea shipping without physically controlling Bab el-Mandeb, as demonstrated since late 2023. Hudaydah, the principal port, remains in Houthi hands and is central to their leverage.

The Three-Front Threat to Saudi Arabia

Saudi Arabia's strategic situation is potentially existential, with simultaneous pressure from Houthis in the south, Iranian-directed Iraqi Shiite militias in the north, and Iran directly to the east. The recent attack on the East West Pipeline, he noted, was consistent with the 2019 Abqaiq/Khuras strike pattern—precise, deniable, and designed to signal Iranian reach.

The Saudis view the entire theater as Iranian-coordinated, involving IRGC officers, Iraqi militias, and the Houthis in a unified pressure campaign. As Iran faces greater constraints on its own oil exports, it will intensify efforts to disrupt Saudi exports—through Houthi attacks, Iraqi militia strikes, or direct Iranian action.

The Mecca Defense Accord—activating Pakistani and Turkish troop deployments—is designed to deter Iranian-backed incursions along Saudi borders by raising the cost of any ground offensive. The deterrent logic: Iranian-backed forces would be killing Pakistani and Turkish soldiers, not just Saudis.

Turkish and Pakistani Capabilities—and Israeli Limits

Turkey has provided a large drone fleet to Saudi Arabia—a meaningful contribution. Pakistan has deployed troops for border and installation defense. Both are seen as capable partners for the current phase of the conflict.

Israeli involvement remains limited. The Saudis have not precluded Israeli participation and already receive some intelligence support through CENTCOM. Israel demonstrated its targeting precision by eliminating the Houthi prime minister and chief of staff in a prior operation. However, there is uncertainty about what Israel could offer that Turkey and Pakistan cannot—beyond high-value targeting intelligence—and the Saudis have so far resisted Israeli offers of direct involvement.

The US Relationship: Disappointment Without Rupture

Saudi frustration with Washington is structural and predates Trump. The current disappointment centers on two specific issues: the US-Houthi backchannel deal (brokered via the US Embassy in Muscat) that exempted American and reportedly Israeli ships from attack, and the absence of a clear presidential-level signal of US support for the anti-Houthi campaign. Secretary Rubio has signaled support; the president has not.

The Saudis want direct US air power involvement, which has not materialized—echoing previous rounds of tension in 2019. They are receiving substantial US support (ISTAR, precision-guided munitions, air

refueling, CENTCOM coordination) but want more.

Normalization: Paused, Not Dead

Normalization with Israel remains a Saudi aspiration, but the conditions are not currently met. The Saudis have obtained several of their pre-7 October asks (a mutual defense framework signed last November, a nuclear agreement in progress, an AI agreement, accelerated weapons purchasing) from Washington without normalizing. They continue to require a meaningful Israeli gesture on Palestinian statehood before proceeding. Israeli elections in October could create an opening—if Netanyahu loses or forms a different coalition—and that the Saudis would like to normalize before Trump's term ends, under the right conditions.

Saudi Domestic and Fiscal Outlook

No domestic challenge to MBS is visible on the horizon. A conflict with the Houthis is more likely to generate nationalist consolidation around him than opposition. He would consider deploying special forces into Yemen but not the regular army at scale, to avoid military casualties from becoming a political problem.

On Saudi finances, the Yemen war should be distinguished from the fiscal pressures, which he attributed to overambitious Vision 2030 projects. The rollback of NEOM and the pivot toward AI infrastructure he characterized as a correction, not a crisis. Saudi Arabia's ability to continue exporting oil keeps it in better fiscal shape than most GCC peers, though its larger population and sovereign wealth fund constraints limit comparisons to Qatar or the UAE.

Key Watch Items

1.

Coastal front trajectory: Whether anti-Houthi forces can reverse Houthi gains at Bab el-Mandeb and Taiz—the prerequisite for any advance toward Hudaydah or Sana'a.

2.

Saudi energy infrastructure attacks: Escalation of Houthi and/or Iraqi militia strikes on Aramco facilities, pipelines, and airports as the campaign intensifies.

3.

Iranian escalation calculus: Whether Iran moves from proxy pressure to direct strikes, particularly if its own oil export constraints deepen.

4.

US signaling: Whether Trump (not just Rubio) issues a clear statement of support for Saudi Arabia and the anti-Houthi campaign, or whether the U.S.-Houthi backchannel expands.

5.

Israeli elections (October): A Netanyahu loss or coalition change could reopen the normalization track, which the Saudis still want to complete before Trump leaves office.

What Clients Are Asking

Rationale for continuing the Yemen campaign: Clients questioned whether Saudi Arabia would be better served by simply ending the blockade and accommodating the Houthis. The "blockade" is an internationally recognized inspection regime, not a full embargo, and that relaxing it would open the door to Iranian weapons and IRGC personnel flowing directly into Sana'a—a redline for Riyadh.

Iran-Yemen linkage: Clients asked whether a diplomatic resolution with Iran would translate into de-escalation in Yemen. The answer is nuanced: the Saudis see one unified theater, but the Houthis have their own strategic interests (controlling all of Yemen, especially southern gas resources) that do not always align with Iranian instructions. A deal with Tehran would not automatically turn off the Houthis.

Saudi-UAE tensions: Clients probed the durability of the current Saudi-UAE coordination. Tensions are structural—competing regional visions, economic rivalry, leadership friction—and the current rapprochement as tactical and Yemen-specific. He expressed surprise that the Iranian threat alone had not been sufficient to produce alignment earlier.

Ukraine's role in GCC defense: Clients asked about Ukrainian anti-drone technology in the Gulf. Ukrainian drone and counter-drone technology is being sold to GCC states and that GCC countries have invested in Ukrainian firms. Firsthand reporting indicates that UAE special forces are deployed on tankers with Ukrainian-supplied anti-drone munitions, and that Saudi Arabia's Bahri shipping line is pursuing a similar approach. Both speakers assessed Ukrainian capabilities as useful against drones but insufficient against ballistic missiles.

MBS's domestic position: Clients sought an assessment of whether the Yemen campaign threatens MBS's standing. There are no organized centers of opposition within Saudi Arabia, and a war with the Houthis is more likely to generate nationalist support than backlash—unless large numbers of Saudi military casualties materialize, which he does not expect.

Please note that while this AI-generated summary has been checked for accuracy against the source material, it may not capture every nuance or qualifier from the discussion. The full transcript or audio should be consulted for complete context.

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